PROJECT 10073 RECORD CARD

1. DATE
2-3 November

2. LOCATION
Vicinity
Levelland, Texas

3. DATE-TIME GROUP
Local 1100-0130 MST
GMT 03/0430Z

4. TYPE OF OBSERVATION
☒ Ground-Visual ☐ Ground-Radar
☐ Air-Visual ☐ Air-Intercept Radar

5. PHOTOS
☐ Yes
☒ No

6. SOURCE
Civilian

7. LENGTH OF OBSERVATION
3 seconds to 4 mins

8. NUMBER OF OBJECTS
one

9. COURSE
varied

10. BRIEF SUMMARY OF SIGHTING
This case triggered off more than 300 similarly described reports within a 5 day period because of the nation-wide publicity and sensationalism given by the press, radio and TV. Oval or round shaped object, generally bluish-white or greenish-white in color.

The size and maneuvers of the obj varied with different (6) observers, which ranged fm the size of a basket ball to 800 feet in length, although the majority reporting that the obj hovered above the ground. Most of the observers stated that the obj affected or stopped their cars ignition. Duration of sightings ranged fm 2 secs to 4 mins. Significant to note that all but one observer mentioned lightning or lightning flashes & the existance of rain or mist in the area.

11. COMMENTS
After very extensive checks and detailed investigations by the Air Force and with complete collaboration with both Air Force & non-governmental scientists it was concluded that the sighting was due to a very rare phenomena, ball lightning.

12. CONCLUSIONS
- ☐ Was Balloon
- ☐ Probably Balloon
- ☐ Possibly Balloon
- ☐ Was Aircraft
- ☐ Probably Aircraft
- ☐ Possibly Aircraft
- ☐ Was Astronomical
- ☐ Probably Astronomical
- ☐ Possibly Astronomical
- ☒ Other Ball lightning
- ☐ Insufficient Data for Evaluation
- ☐ Unknown

ATIC FORM 329 (REV 26 SEP 52)

LEVELLAND, TEXAS "BLUE LIGHT" CASE
2 November 1957

Five witnesses report seeing objects in the vicinity of Levelland, Texas on the night of 2 November 1957. The time reported by these witnesses is between 2300 and 2400 hours. The general description of the UFO's is that they were round to oval in shape and ranged from the size of a baseball to a basketball. The colors reported were white with a greenish tint, blue, reddish glow, red and a flash of white light. Several of the witnesses reported that the engine of their car died due to electrical disturbances. The duration of most of these sightings was approximately several seconds. At 2045 on 4 November 1957, a witness reported an UFO as red and the size of a basketball, connected to a larger darker object by what appeared to be a cable. After approximately three or four minutes the object rose and disappeared into the base of the clouds.

The weather at the time of the sightings on 2 November 1957, was a 400' overcast, visibility three miles, light and variable. There was a drizzle or light rain throughout the period and the area had been subjected to heavy thunderstorms just prior to the sightings. The weather on the 4th of November 1957, thick heavy clouds and light rain.

It is concluded that the cause of the sightings on 2 November 1957, was probably due to a phenomena known as "Ball Lightning". The cause for the witnesses cars stopping could be attributed to the sudden disposition of moisture on distributor parts, especially if moisture condensation nuclei were enhanced by increased atmospheric ionization. In one instance a faulty distributor was determined as being the cause for the motor stoppage.

The object sighted on 4 November 1957, was probably a weather balloon with the safety light which is attached to these balloons for night launchings.

RETURN TO:
Director
Aerospace Studies Inst
ATTN: Archives Branch
Maxwell AFB, Alabama
K243.6012-1
23 Nov 1957

CONDITIONS MIGHT HAVE DEVELOPED TO BRING ABOUT ST ELMO FIRE OR THE LIKE PD 2. POSSIBILITY OF EXCESS BURNING GAS FROM OIL OPERATIONS REFLECTION OFF 400 FOOT CLOUD COVER PD 3. POSSIBILITY OF DOWNED POWER LINE SPARKING OFF WET GROUND PD SOUTHWESTER PUBLIC SERVICE CO IS CHECKING WITH REA COOPS ON ANY OTHER CONCERN WITH POWER LINES INTO AREA FOR FAILURE PD SOUTHWESTERN IS POWER COMPANY IN AREA PD THEY WILL PHONE INFO RECEIVED TO REESE AFB WHO WILL FORWARD TO THIS ORTANIZATION PD DR RALPH S UNERWOOD CMM TEXAS TECH ASTRONOMY EXPERT CMM STATED THAT THE FOLLOWING POSSIBILITIES EXISTED AS HE UNDERSTOOD THE SIGHTING CLN NATURAL PHENOMENA NOT FULLY UNDERSTAND CMM POSSIBLY CAUSED BY RAIN CMM AND HE STATED THAT THE POSSIBILITY EXISTED THAT THEY CAME FROM OUTER SPACE BUT HE PERSONALLY DID NOT BELIEVE THIS TO BE THE CASE PD DR UNDERWOOD ALSO CONCURED WITH NUMBERS ONE AND TWO ABOVE PD END PRCLIMINARY REPORT PD AF FORM 112 WILL FOLLOW AS SOON AS POSSIBLE PD END

BT

07/0115Z NOV RJEDDN

26

TO USAF PD PRESS RELEASE ALSO STATED THAT FARMER IN

* Rept shows Common earth-make hand dial

IMMEDIATE AREA HAD EXPERIENCED POWER FAILURE IN HIS TRUCK AT APPROXIMATE TIME OF THIS SIGHTING PD INVESTIGATION PROVED THAT A ROTOR HAD BEEN CHANGED ON THE FARMERS TRUCK THE PREVIOUS DAY PD ONE PIECE OF THE OLD ROTOR HAD NOT BEEN REMOVED AND HAD WEDGED IN BETWEEN THE POINTS CAUSING THE ELECTRICAL SYSTEM TO BE NOW NON OPERATIVE PD THIS STATEMENT WAS OBTAINED FROM THE MECHANIC WHO HAD REPAIRED THE TRUCK PD AF FORM 112 WILL FOLLOW AS SOON AS POSSIBLE PD END

BT

29/2226Z NOV RJEDDN

>S

Analyst's Comments or Conclusions:

"Ball Lightning" -

1. In the opinion of the undersigned, after careful search, study, and consideration of all data available, the phenomenon was undoubtedly related to the meteorological conditions that existed in the area at that time: fog, light rain, mist, very low ceiling (400 feet) and lightning discharges. The latter were definitely established through the results of numerous investigative reports.

2. Probably contributing to the phenomenon were the oil fires that were also burning in the vicinity. An oil-saturated mist is capable of producing a "fluorescent glow" (as described) upon excitation from a lightning discharge.

3. In summation, all of the above were conducive to a "ball lightning" manifestation -- a field, of which very little is known by admission of writers and authorities themselves (Dr. John Trombridge, Enclop. Am.; Prof. T. A. Blair, Univ. of Nebraska, Weather Elements, among others).

4. All are in agreement, however, of the following, which, significantly, are the almost exact characteristics and descriptions of the "Levelland phenomena":

a. Ball lightning can take many unusual or weird spherical or elliptical shapes.

b. It is predominantly brilliant blue-or bluish-white in color.

c. It can float slowly some distance above the ground.

5. The close proximity of ball lightning or lightning discharges is capable of ionizing the air that may, in turn, effect moisture-laden ignition components of a motor vehicle.

George T. Gregory

Capt. GT T. Gregory
3 Jan 1958

Case was submitted to Dr. J. Allen Hynek, Northwestern Astrophysical Observatory for his interest review and comment — appended herein, as is Hynek letter. Note A.F. scientists further comments.

G T G. Jan 13, 1958

(Also see USSR Scientist, Kaptsov's work in this field — just received in 1957 and translated)

1. LEVELLAND INCIDENT - 2 November 1957 (UNCLASSIFIED)

a. A mysterious object, whose shape was described variously as ranging from round to oval, and predominantly bluish-white in color was observed separately by six persons near the town of Levelland, Texas. Times of observations ranged from 2300 hours to after 0130 hours, night of 2-3 November 1957. Size of the object was estimated from that of a basketball to that of an object 200 feet in length.

b. The unusual aspect of this incident was the statement by a number of observers that their car's ignition stopped completely during the occurrence.

c. In a matter of hours this incident was given nation-wide publicity by the nation's press, radio and TV networks. For the next 72 hours ATIC and Headquarters USAF were deluged with a flood of UFO reports, the majority of observers claiming to have encountered a somewhat similar phenomenon: a dazzling bluish-white object, generally oval in shape, swooping down or floating nearby - that stopped their car's ignition. The reports were from persons of some standing in their communities casually reporting seeing the objects to those insisting that the "blue lights" stopped their cars in heavy traffic in the middle of large cities during broad daylight.

d. Intensive investigations produced information not generally given by newspapers and other media previously. For example: it was pitch dark, rain and mist was falling, a very low ceiling existed, there were lightning discharges, and the sightings took place near an area where excess gases from oil operations were being burned. In some instances, faulty ignition systems and near freezing temperatures were found during the investigations.

e. A number of the observers interviewed admitted the presence of lightning or flashes of light. The prime source could not be located for interview and interrogations by USAF investigators.

f. After exhaustive studies and analyses by the Air Force, and in full collaboration with outside scientists and experts, it was concluded that the sighting was due to a very rare lightning phenomenon - ball lightning. No definite conclusion has been reached regarding the possible effects of ball lightning on ignition systems. (All agreed that the combination of conditions existing in the area at the time were definitely conducive to the phenomenon. A study of the very few existing photographs of actual ball lightning further confirmed the conclusion.)